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Rick Montalbano

Rick Montalbano is the among the most respected musicians in upstate New York. As a full time musician, he has carved out his own niche as a versatile pianist, organist, arranger and band leader. Rick has performed with and employed many of the finest jazz artists in the business including Nick Brignola, Sal Amico, Sal Nistico and Delores Mancuso.

Rick was interviewed in Clinton, New York at the Hamilton College Jazz Archive, on August 12, 2011 by Monk Rowe, director of the Jazz Archive. Romy Britell, the Archive's transcriptionist, participated briefly in the interview.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and I'm sitting off-camera in the jazz archive at Hamilton College, and I'm very pleased to have my good friend Rick Montalbano here. I'm finally going to be able to talk to you about how the heck you make a living in the music business.

RM: Yeah.

MR: And you just said it I think. You said you live in the cracks.

RM: Right.

MR: So can you expand upon that?

RM: Well I was referring to my work in some of the institutions of higher education in the area.

MR: Yeah.

RM: I'm there in several colleges but you kind of don't — is he there? — does he — you know. You just kind of are in the shadows you see. It's better that people don't know me, that I just go do my job and — can you quickly turn off the tape?

MR: Yeah, I just, I did want to point out, you see these notebooks here, you're surrounded by — every word you say is going to be like, you can't take it back now.

RM: Okay, let's go backwards.

MR: This is take two.

RM: Right.

MR: No but I know what you mean. And there's a certain advantage of not getting involved in campus politics and academia can be like a pretty brutal place.

RM: Yeah. Yes it can. Especially since I didn't come up that way either. So I'm a foreigner.

MR: Well that sort of anticipates the curiosity I've had about what was your music school, quotes around it.

RM: It was the John Jaski school of accordion. I played the accordion when I started, when I was about eleven and a half or something. That's how I started. I took a couple of years of accordion lessons. That was basically it. And then a few — along the way I did, you

know, a lesson here or there, I took a couple of lessons with Jim Straney, but I actually didn't have a piano then. So that was kind of weird. And then in my thirties I tried to play a little classical music with Joanne Geller. But basically I took — the kid who lived upstairs from me, his family was right from Italy, and you know, the neighborhoods in the fifties how they were — he played the accordion and his cousin would come over, a guy who would play the mandolin and they'd be on the porch in the summer and playing all these old Italian songs, and I listened and I thought I could do it. And I borrowed ten bucks from my sister and followed him to a lesson. My parents didn't know. My mom was in the hospital I think at the time, and I just borrowed some money and followed him and walked to his lesson and I came home with a rental accordion and I had a half-hour accordion lesson and that was it.

MR: No kidding?

RM: No.

MR: Was the Italian community, or that heritage, a big part of your life?

RM: Yeah. Well I would say the neighborhood. That type of neighborhood in the 1950's, that was big, a huge part, yeah. Still is. And in some ways I never left there. You know all these years later I'm playing at the Savoy in Rome which is about 25 yards from where I grew up, right out the back door of the place. So it took me 62 years and I made it 25 yards. You know I haven't come very far in my career. But that was basically it, those lessons.

MR: Did you decide, yourself, at some point, that your career or your livelihood was going to be in music or did it just sort of happen?

RM: It just happened. I started playing very young, gigs. By the time I was 13 I was out on the weekends making money and, you know, and that was it. Once I got money in my pocket I was good to go.

MR: Can you remember the first time you made money and how much was it?

RM: Twenty dollars.

MR: Twenty dollars?

RM: Twenty dollars. Yeah.

MR: That's a lot.

RM: That was a lot. Yeah. I was knocked out by that. They didn't all pay that, and some of those things I did early on they passed the hats, they were little things at the Moose Club and those kinds of things. Always with the older musicians, I was always the kid. And John Jaski at the time, my accordion teacher, he had a band and he would double book himself, and then he would send me out on a gig, with his amp, you know he'd give me an amp and I'd bring the accordion and I'd play with a couple of guys somewhere. And

sometime during the night he would leave one place and he'd just go show up at the other place, just like "hi folks, here I am."

MR: You know we both need someone like that, to do that.

RM: To double book us.

MR: Yeah. You go there and play the first half hour.

RM: We should do that. Yeah. Absolutely.

MR: So what would the repertoire at that time have consisted of?

RM: Standards. Dance music. You know it was all for dancing. And I recently had the thought doing all this teaching that one of the differences between like the kids I have today, I mean like the really good, gifted kids who play a lot and go on into music, the difference is they don't have to play music for dancing anymore. Does it happen beyond the world of DJ's? Not very much I don't think. So everything we played — so I didn't start playing and say oh I'm playing jazz. We were just playing songs. Standard songs. And in a dance style. The important thing was people kept dancing and we played medleys and we'd play a foxtrot and string four or five tunes together. That type of thing. So it was always songs and learning lots of material. And along the way there was improvisation involved but it wasn't maybe full out soloing per se, you know like taking a chorus or something. It wasn't that exactly. It was more based around the melody and a little stretching out from that.

MR: Like what you need to do at the Savoy.

RM: Basically yes. Yes, that's right. And I don't stray too far because in that context people don't necessarily know what's going on. You played the song but then you just went off somewhere and did something else, but then you came back and played the song again. Actually, Monk, I consider it quite a challenge to do that, to keep playing, without the advantage of, like you're going to play one tune and take seven choruses. So you have to do more material and you have to maybe consider other ways of rendering a melody that are still interesting to me. You know? I still get something out of it.

MR: What made you switch from accordion to piano?

RM: Just as soon as I got near a piano, every time I got near a piano I'd try to play it. The first time, you know the accordion you're looking, obviously you're looking down at the keys. So I can remember the first time I went to a piano at my cousin's house I looked at it and I had to go, oh, there it is, you know.

MR: I'd never thought of that.

RM: Yeah. That's absolutely true. So I had to kind of try to find my place. It's a whole other visual.

MR: That's neat. Well you mentioned a thing about playing with older musicians, and I know that there's been some good mentors in this area, even though I didn't grow up here when I got here I started to recognize people that were from that older generation.

RM: Yes.

MR: Who were those people for you?

RM: Well early on Jack Palmer, a huge mentor for me. And of course Sammy Mancuso and Dolores Mancuso. Chick Esposito. You know when we were involved in that band and I would hang out with Chick a lot and do gigs with him and I learned a lot of stuff from him, and then later with Sal Amico, I mean later, like in my later teen years. Sal Amico and then of course J.R. [Monterose] and Sal Nistico and Nick Brignola. But initially I would say Jack Palmer, a huge influence. Not only about the music but about business, how to conduct yourself on a gig, how to talk to people.

MR: Just by watching him?

RM: Yes. Oh he would tell you too. Yeah, he'd take you aside if you did something that wasn't quite up to his standards you know. Yeah, he would tell you. And he had, as you know, you knew Jack and I saw some of that interview you did with him, which was fantastic. He was quite a guy.

MR: Yeah. Did you have, at that point in your late teens when you were playing with these guys, did you have a *Real Book*?

RM: No.

MR: Okay, so how did you learn the tunes?

RM: Well there was that initial fake book, they used to call it "the bible" remember that old thing?

MR: Oh yeah. "For Professional Use Only."

RM: That's right. Only later did I realize there was a whole system that people bought with drawers and there were like five by eight cards with one tune on each, and you bought them and you had your filing cabinet full of tunes. Someone gave me a ton of those not that long ago. So you would buy this service. And every month you would get however many tunes, then you'd put them in the slot and then of course some enterprising person took them and copied them and put them all in a book, there were three per page I think.

MR: Oh right. Sure.

RM: Three, at least three per page. So there was that. And of course that wasn't that accurate in terms of chord changes or even melodies sometimes. And they didn't give you all of the information. They didn't include verses to tunes or, you know. But it was a help to some degree. I can remember Jack Palmer, when I first started playing with him, he took the book and in the index he put a checkmark and he said "learn these tunes" and there

were about 400 tunes that he checked off. He said "these tunes will take you anywhere in the world." And he was right of course.

MR: Well you know that partly answers this question I have, but you know when I moved to Rome you actually hired me — my first significant gig I think was with you, at the Beeches there. And I remember thinking at the time, I thought I was a pretty good musician.

RM: You were.

MR: Well I didn't know a lot. And I watched you and Carmen and Dolores, and especially you and Carmen, like how you handled that gig. So I'm a bit curious like how did you know that? Because we're almost the same age, but I had no idea at the time. How did you learn how to play that gig?

RM: Well by that point I had played a lot of gigs for a lot of years, since I was 13 years old. And they were essentially the same kind of gig, one variation — aside from a few years with rock groups and, you know, on the road with some crazy bands. But most of the gigs were that kind of dance music, jazz, you know, not a full out blowing gig but, you know. So there was a lot of years there. And yeah, that information was not necessarily from that fake book either, I don't mean to imply by that fake book like that was all you needed to know. It was from listening to recordings and bands, and there weren't, as I remember, there wasn't really jazz education at that time. At least not that I knew. I remember one book, Bugs Bower or something, with little phrases and things, and I bought that book and I looked through that thing and, okay now what. Now do I know how to play? Take the book on a gig? So it was from listening and trying to figure out things from endless hours with recordings, and then watching bands and looking over people's shoulders, and the advice of people like Sammy and Chick.

MR: I can recall people coming up and requesting a song, "Flamingo" or even something that might have been on the radio at the time like "Spanish Eyes" or something.

RM: Right.

MR: And I remember specifically you'd look at Carmen and you might say a key. And on occasion you guys would play it but you didn't know the bridge, and you'd make it up. And I would watch these people who had requested it, oh I'm so happy you played my song. I said this is important to learn.

RM: Yeah. Well as you're saying that I'm thinking about my mom. My mother, who you knew, she knew every song, I think every standard song ever written. She knew them all. She could sing the lyrics. She was not a musician, and she wasn't a singer, but she would buy these books of lyrics, the hit parade books, I'm talking about from the 1940's on. And she would look at the lyrics and every song that would come on the radio, anything that would play, bang, she would start singing. Sometimes it would be "mom," you

know, "please." Yeah. So a lot of that was growing up and hearing that music. Another advantage if you're going to play standards, and the kids today don't necessarily get that in their homes, you know, in the background, you have to seek it out. We didn't have to seek out that music, it was the music of our lives. That was what we heard. Sinatra and Ella and, you know, my father, another non-musician but he loved Count Basie's band and all the great big bands and all that. So that's kind of what we heard.

MR: Were they happy that you became a professional musician?

RM: Well yeah, because I paid rent every week from when I was 14 or 15 years old. I was thinking about that recently too and I realized well I was paying them twenty dollars a week — twenty, forty, sixty, eighty dollars a month. Their rent was $75 a month. I paid the rent. No wonder they liked me.

MR: No kidding? You paid rent to basically stay at home?

RM: Yeah. Oh, well all my brothers did. That was part of what you did in those days too. You contributed back to the family. So there was that kind of work ethic. Meat and potatoes music business, go out and earn money and play gigs and, you know, whatever you had to do to play a gig you worked on.

MR: Who took you to the gigs when you were 15?

RM: My parents sometimes, sometimes the people that would hire me. Jack Palmer, the first gig I can remember the trip with him, he came and picked me up and I wish I could tell you that story but unfortunately I can't. But after Romy leaves and we're alone, I'll tell you the first thing he ever said to me in the car on the way to a gig, which is very funny but —

MR: Okay, that's for part two which will be inaccessible.

RM: Yeah. Will not be aired.

MR: Did you see things — I could ask it this way. Did you see behavior on gigs that you had to make a judgement about. Am I going to choose to drink like this person, and all that kind of stuff?

RM: Yeah, sure. John Jaski, go back to him, he would give me an amp to take to a gig. And I remember once taking an amp and as I'm taking it in there was a rattling like crazy and I thought oh my God, the tubes came out, I broke some tubes in his amp. And when I got there I looked in the back of the amp and there were all these pill bottles filled with — he used to make Manhattans at home and fill up these pill bottles with them, and so during the gig he would just reach back into the amp and bango. So everybody — there was a lot of heavy drinking in musicians. Some of the behaviors, actually it was later on when I played with rock groups and I thought man you guys are so unprofessional. It was crazy, because I was always with the adults you know. So there was a certain kind of way you

presented yourself. And when I saw that kind of amateurish — with people that I was playing with — it was a little disturbing.

MR: What would have been the repertoire for the rock stuff you were doing? This was from the sixties?

RM: The sixties. Yeah.

MR: Young Rascals?

RM: Yeah, yeah. The Beatles. One group was like, in those days, it was like '67, '68, we called it hard rock. Today I don't know if you would call it heavy metal or, I don't know. But there was a lot of English groups, The Easy Beats, and of course the Rolling Stones and the Beatles stuff and loud rock & roll. Yeah. Not fifties rock & roll. Definitely 60's rock & roll.

MR: In other words, you guys were playing current material.

RM: Yeah, we were playing the music of the day. Steppenwolf and I had a Hammond organ by that point.

MR: That must have been a big investment.

RM: Yeah. Yeah. I bought that when I was, I don't know, 17, 18 years old. It comes from all those years, honestly, of just making money. I always had a pocketful of money from playing gigs. I wish I did today.

MR: I'm going to take a guess that those rock bands didn't necessarily make you more money than the club dates.

RM: No. Oh those were, oh my God those were strange days, Monk. Being on the road in those days. Five guys in a van with all of our equipment and all of our clothes and all of our money, and it was just like a band commune, you know. We shared everything. We traveled all over the place and there was no rhyme or reason. We'd be in Boston and then the next day we'd be in Waterloo, Iowa. Crazy. And driving around and sharing the driving and all of that. And of course when it was time to pick out clothes it was just a big pile of clothes. We'd all come in and just dump clothes. And then there'd be a fight. Sometimes there would be an actual fist fight for a shirt. That's how it got on the road. That's probably the only story I can tell you about being on the road.

MR: Yeah. Probably five guys in the motel room too.

RM: Yeah. In one room or two rooms. Yeah never more than that. Sneaking in and out of places. Sometimes not having the money to pay for the room and sneaking out. Everything you heard about the sixties was right and then some.

MR: All this time were you listening to jazz music? You know, like let's say Coltrane or the piano players? I'm thinking — I'm not sure how to phrase this, or even if it's a question, but that was a goal also?

RM: Yeah. Well of course yeah. I was heavily into Miles Davis especially. The Miles Davis of the sixties. I was very monolithic in my taste. I listened to Miles, I would listen to one record night after night after night after night. And in those days the old hi-fi, I had a stereo system with the two little speakers, and I put them in bed with me. And I would earmuff myself with the speakers. And if you lifted up the changer arm, you know the little handle at the top where you could stack records, if you lifted it up on this particular thing it would play the record and then it would come back and drop it back about halfway through the first track again. Never all the way to the end, and then it would play again, and all night long. So I'd go to sleep with it, and I'd wake up in the morning. That was my flirtation with learning through osmosis, which I'm not sure worked. But yeah, Herbie Hancock and Tony Williams and Wayne Shorter or George Coleman, and Miles and Ron Carter of course. And that was it. I thought that was the end-all to music. I didn't like anything before that. You know people were trying to play Charlie Parker, "I don't want to hear that old stuff." That was nuts. It was just, that music was just so fascinating to me that I could barely listen to anything else. So yeah, all during that time, there was always that going on. That was my background noise.

MR: That's really interesting you say that because I was sort of trying to phrase a question I've been asking recently this question that has to do with wrong notes when you're improvising.

RM: Wrong notes.

MR: Wrong notes. Or are there any wrong notes? And when I think of Miles especially, and I listen to Miles, sometimes he plays these notes like where'd that come from? Did he do that on purpose? Was it a cracked note but because it's Miles it's okay? I mean when you play or when you teach your students, do you ever sort of deal with the idea of right and wrong notes?

RM: I try to phrase it as better choices. In Miles' case, I mean he did crack. A lot of people didn't listen to him. I can remember trumpet players — Jack Palmer. Jack Palmer loved what he played and he hated his sound. He used to say "ah Miles Davis, you might as well be playing with a comb and wax paper, you know. That's what it sounded like, and especially when he put the Harmon in. You know. But I can't imagine that he — the thing is with, if you're calling them wrong notes, I guess anything, if you put it in the proper context you can make virtually anything from the chromatic scale work. Any note can work over something if it's played the right way and I think if its enough in the moment to deal with the sound you just made and make it work somehow you know. Early on you know — I'm sure you remember this — it was that if you played something you'd play it again, as if you did — but that's kind of, I think, a little superficial. But I think the idea of being enough in the moment helps in that regard to take a particular

sound that maybe initially is a rub against the chord and kind of work your way back in or whatever. So it has a lot to do with that thing of being in it, which is the cause of a lot of frustration sometimes. I mean that to me is the single most important thing, in my case at least, being able to filter everything out and be in the now. I know it sounds a little corny but you know what I'm saying.

MR: Is that kind of thing teachable?

RM: Well you can describe it. Whether or not they can get there totally is up to them. You can certainly point people in that direction I think. But you know how it is, I mean especially at this level, the teaching takes on more of a theoretical viewpoint I think, teaching voicings and working through all those things. And then later on, as you know, I mean you learn all this stuff and it takes you however many years to learn it, then you have to unlearn everything and it takes you another ten years to unlearn, to figure out what not to play out of what you figured out what to play. I sound like I know what I'm talking about. I don't know. I don't have a clue what I'm saying.

MR: I think when we transcribe that, that one will go in capital letters.

RM: It's a mystery wrapped in a conundrum inside of an enigma. I don't know. But truly, you know, that unlearning things — not unlearning — but figuring out what not to do is a huge part of everything. I think in younger students today you can kind of condense that procedure. I think people of our age or older, I mean it probably took a little longer to get there because we didn't have 75 thousand books on theory.

MR: Yeah. And the play-a-long records and all that stuff.

RM: Jamey Abersold and all of that.

MR: Yeah. You know Jamey says "Anyone Can Improvise."

RM: Really.

MR: Yes. So —

RM: And by improvise you mean on an instrument or just in conversation?

MR: Maybe that's what he means.

RM: Like I'm walking this way and I decide I'm going to walk over there for a second. I don't know.

MR: So let me ask about a few people that you've shared the bandstand with. I remember when you left to go play with Lou Rawls, and I think you were pretty excited about that.

RM: Oh yeah definitely.

MR: I remember going to your house and I think you had a Rhodes —

RM: Yes.

MR: And you were working on the music and you know, I felt really happy for you. Was that a good experience?

RM: That was a great experience. That was a wonderful experience, especially becoming friends with some of the people in the band — Don Alias in particular. So I highly recommend, of course our friend is gone now, but the idea of going on the road with Don Alias, more so actually than Lou Rawls, it was thrilling to me. And every day was a thrill really, because we played every day. He and I played every day. Virtually every day, aside from travel days.

MR: You mean the two of you?

RM: Yeah.

MR: Okay. You'd find a way to —

RM: We'd find a way to — we'd get up early, have some coffee and go right to the club and, you know the lights would be off and the club would be shut down and we'd come in through the kitchen and we'd play. Whether it was with organ and drums or electric piano and a set of bongos, or whatever it was, or two keyboards, or anything. We made music every day. Maybe that was the single most inspiring time of my life, or inspired maybe I should say — with Don. And of course then Jaco [Pastorius] was on the scene then, before anybody knew who he was. He did actually play in the band for a minute. He didn't last long.

MR: He probably — did he have trouble fitting into being a bass player in the Lou Rawls band? What it took?

RM: Not in my estimation. No. Other people in the band had problems with it.

MR: I see.

RM: You know. But no, again, it was a thrill beyond belief. And not because, he didn't have any name then, I mean it wasn't like the great Jaco Pastorius, it was just this phenomenal, incredible sound coming out of an electric bass, and you're looking, is there something hooked up? I used to bring recordings of him back. I was taping all the time then. I had a little SONY cassette recorder and I taped everything. And it was the Watergate years. So I would bring tapes back and I remember playing for Sammy Mancuso and he would go "what? No. That's a Fender Rhodes." "No, no man, it's a bass. It's an electric bass." "No." Because he was doing the chords, you know, the harmonic stuff, all of that business. Then other people thought you sped up the tape. You know you played it in normal, like a human being, and then you sped up the tape to make it seem like he was playing so fast and all of that.

MR: What was your take on how he got that sound? It seemed like even if he just played a couple of notes that he had that sound. Was he playing a fretless?

RM: It was a fretless bass. As I recall it was, he made it a fretless bass. He took the frets off and filled them in and did all that. But it was an amplified sound, from his hands, the way he used his fingers and the way — it was him. That was his sound. It was like nothing in

those years, it was like nothing I'd ever heard before. I don't think anyone had ever heard a sound like that. Not that I know of, coming out of a bass. It was just startling when you first hear it. And he was a great, great kid back then. We had a ball. We had so much fun and so many laughs, and Don and Jaco and myself, crazy stuff. Yeah. Nothing like where he ended up. Complete health nut, running, and sports you know, playing basketball and running all the time, and I couldn't keep up with him you know.

MR: That's too bad. Did he play more than he needed on the gig? Is that why he didn't last?

RM: In Lou's band?

MR: Yeah.

RM: Again, not in my estimation, Monk. I may have a slightly skewed perspective because I was so in favor of him being in the band and wanting him to be out on the road with us, so maybe I overlooked something. But I don't think so. I just think it was so different. No he played the music, he played it beautifully man. You know. He instantly could do the whole thing. No it wasn't like he was soloing and playing crazy busy behind Lou or anything. Yeah, I think he caused a little fear in some people you know. And he had some ideas about rearranging Lou's book. He was a great arranger you know, a great musical mind, at the piano and the whole thing, which was another thing I was looking forward to. Because by that time I was a little tired of playing that music the same way every night, and you know.

MR: A lot of those gigs, you had a core rhythm section and if it was going to be a large band and you would go to a town and there would be the local guys filling the chairs?

RM: Yeah. Well we were fortunate. Sometimes we played a lot in New York and it was always Buddy Rich's horn section and you'd get some good bands on the west coast and here and there. Sometimes it was a little tough but, you know, we were together. We were a unit so we made it work. We could have made it work without the big band. And we did, night after night. So it wasn't that much of a problem that the band was not that together.

MR: I'll bet you had to adjust your playing.

RM: Yeah. It was lot less organ, you know bigger organ sounds, and it was a lot more stepping back a little bit, you know, into the mix.

MR: Right. How was Lou Rawls' work from the time you joined the band? Did it stay consistent?

RM: He worked a lot. He worked like crazy, especially the first year. Yeah. And it was a ball. We had a great time. He was a ball to work with. He liked to work. He liked to be out there working. He had gone through a divorce I guess and needed to make some money. So.

MR: Do you recall what you were making at that time, if you don't mind my asking?

RM: Maybe four or five hundred dollars a week, which was a lot of money back then. Oh my God. When I came off of the road I had so much money saved, and I spent a lot of money. You know I had probably a hundred dollar a week phone bills back then calling home to my wife. And I always managed to put money away and I had a little nest egg.

MR: Over the years you've found, out of desire and/or necessity, you've found ways to wear many hats, work at the casino, become a music contractor. Do you just sort of fall into those things and say, yeah, I probably could do that?

RM: Yes. [Phone rings] Excuse me it's my dog bothering me.

MR: How much is that doggy?

RM: In the window? All right Angelina. It's somewhere buried in here. Sorry about that.

MR: Do you know that Bucky Pizzarelli played on "How Much is that Doggy in the Window?"

RM: That doesn't surprise me. Is that okay to put that there?

MR: Yeah.

RM: All right.

RB: It's buzzing though. It's the microphone.

RM: Okay.

MR: Oh, all right.

RM: How's that.

MR: That's good.

RM: Okay.

MR: But things like music contracting, those take another skill. You have to be pretty darn organized and, did you find, yeah I can do that stuff.

RM: Yes. And I'm not pretty darn organized. I just, I don't know, I just was kind of, well first of all I just fell into it like everything else. You know things just happened. An opportunity is there and you do it, and it wasn't a conscious thinking now I've got to do this or that. Just like playing. It kind of took me along for the ride. But I'm fortunate because I'm involved with the Central NY Jazz Orchestra and we have a working big band, and I have an opportunity to do arranging when I want to, in an organized, more than just a pick-up band. So when things come into the casino, you know I have really talented guys, Pat Carney, one of the best lead trumpet players anywhere. Joe Corello, the lead alto player who could play in any band anywhere. You know you have strong people like that and sections within the band that worked. You know Joe saw to it that the saxophone section phrased and breathed together, and Pat, you know, everybody knew he was the leader. So we had good guys that were used to working with one another. So I had a ready-made band, really, to bring into the casino for those types of gigs. And

whenever there were strings involved it was usually the Syracuse Symphony people. Yeah. Did I answer your question?

MR: Yeah I think so. I mean it's much like me, you sort of like find ways to fill your time that hopefully make you money, you know, and you're in the music business still.

RM: Yeah. Right.

MR: Even if you are doing paperwork and all that other stuff.

RM: Right.

MR: I think it helps to be a musician doing that. We know stuff that non-musicians don't know about.

RM: Right.

MR: I'm going to take a guess that when you were describing playing with Don Alias every day, that's where some of your left hand bass playing came from?

RM: Well it certainly probably strengthened at that point. My feeling for the phrasing and time in general, you know, it was like an awakening aspect of playing time playing with Don, that I really hadn't experienced at that level. But the bass line really came before then. There was an organ player that used to come through the area by the name of Wendell Byrd and he was quite notorious. And at the time there was a couple of clubs around Central New York, Birdland in Utica was one and Benevin's Lounge in Rome. And it was still part of that kind of organ circuit. Newark, New Jersey. Lou used to call it the "chitlin circuit." It wasn't quite that but it was sort of like an offshoot of that. Okay? Yeah. There were organ clubs in the sixties. And Wendell would come to Rome. He would play in Utica at Birdland and he would come to Rome, especially when I was really, I don't know I was 15 years old and play at Benevin's and I would go in, and I became friends with him, and he showed me the first bass line that I ever played, on a blues in F. And to this day I remember exactly the bass line he showed me. I worked on that thing over and over and over and over, to the point where I thought I'm never going to be able to do this. And then one day I could suddenly put my hands together and everything worked. And that was where the bass line stuff came from, from playing the B3. And it was definitely — as an aside — it was in the hand. Everybody thinks it's on the pedals. There are some people who play pedals on the B3, but few and far between who actually play the pedals. It's the left hand. That's why it's the B3 because you can get that particular sound on the lower manual, and then you kind of — he faked his foot you know. He just moved his foot in tandem with his left hand and they used to have like a mirror behind him and you would see that foot going like crazy, and I used to watch his foot and think oh my God that's incredible. And then one day I hear the bass line going up and his foot was going down, so I thought that's a little odd. And then he showed me all the little secrets and the settings and all of that. And of course all of the organ tricks —

put the matchbook cover between keys to hold the key down while you're playing underneath it and then you'd get up and leave and the organ would still be playing. You know the drummer would solo for 45 minutes. Sometimes you'd go to a bar and have a couple of drinks. A few times he actually just went home. And then finally the drummer would get tired and turn off the organ.

MR: Oh that's priceless.

RM: And then he always gave me little tips like when you're done, when you're done with the set, push the drawbars in. You don't want people coming up and figuring out how you get those sounds you know. So yeah, you finished the set, boom, boom, boom, you pushed all the drawbars in. He was a riot this guy. His brother was Jerry Byrd, a very good guitar player who recorded a lot and played with lots of people.

MR: You know you wouldn't have a prayer now keeping that secret because people would just go behind you and they'd take out their phone and they'd take a picture of your drawbars.

RM: Yeah. And of course everything, I mean you can go on the Internet and see everybody's telling you everything. All the information is there. You know I thought I was in some secret club, you know? And now you just want to learn what the settings are, and you go and Joey DeFrancesco's website or something else, they show you how to play bass lines, they show you the settings, how to do this and that, you know. Again, it's the idea that everything is compressed. What took us longer, now you can get all that information and figure it out all very quickly because it's all readily available.

MR: Is that a good thing or a bad thing?

RM: I think it's good and bad. Yeah. And plus it bugs me that I didn't have it. That's the main thing.

MR: Yeah I hear a lot about, well over the years I've heard a lot about Birdland. Where was it?

RM: Birdland was in Bagg's Square in Utica, where Genesee going north with the bridge — you know where the museum —

MR: The Children's Museum is now.

RM: On the other side.

MR: Okay.

RM: Well that was generally Bagg's Square. It's all torn down now. And Birdland was part of that scene down there with a great little scene. They had a B3. Dicky Frank ran the place and he was a terrific guy. And I played there six nights a week for the better part of a year with the great Tina Brooks, a saxophone player, of all people, I ended up playing with Tina Brooks when I was 18 years old. We had a great drummer by the name of Ronnie Jackson, that was the group, with the B3.

MR: Boy. What an education.

RM: Yes.

MR: Well I got my education, watching — because I used to sit at the Beeches, I mean that was a big thing for me. I don't know if you realize. That gig was a big thing for me. For one thing, watching you guys operate. But also because I used to sit at the left end of the organ and I'd watch your hand. I'd go, oh, I have to learn how to do that. It must have been a pretty big thing when they came out with an electronic keyboard that had a decent piano sound and that you could split the keyboard.

RM: Yes. It made things a lot easier to work. And of course, like you, I bought that mini Moog from you. I used to carry that thing around and put it on top of the Rhodes. It was always one keyboard or another. A little synthesizer you'd put on top, or sometimes it would be over to the left so I learned how to play like this, and totally wrecked my back of course. Now everything's just one. Yeah. It's a lot nicer.

MR: What aggravates you musically, with other musicians?

RM: Loud, overly loud playing bugs me. Trying to play jazz too loud. I don't think it's meant to play loud. And being on stages with big PA systems and monitors. You're at the mercy of — with all due respect — you're at the mercy of soundmen. Your life is now in their hands. Everything seems to have gone more in the hands of the technical people — the engineers and the sound people. So they control your sound. And plus just in general trying to play jazz too loud. And the other thing that bugs me is probably players who don't know enough tunes, you know, who have to open up a Real Book. If you call a tune the Real Book is always there. It's kind of a sign lately that if you're on a gig and somebody immediately puts up a Real Book you know you might be in a little trouble.

MR: Those are the kinds of things that would put a player down sort of on your B list or your C list, as far as who you're going to call.

RM: Yeah.

MR: What about musical, even specifically musical things that you like in other players. Is it possible to put it into words?

RM: Well probably part of it. I would say one of the things I really like is people who can play a melody, render a melody, phrase it with beautiful conversational type phrasing, you know, like a Sinatra phrasing let's say. I'd say if every musician would sit down with those Sinatra records and literally copy his phrasing, the breathing points and the bigger curve of his phrasing, I think everyone would sound better. You know there's a lot of concentration on just soloing and the eighth notes and immediately into that aspect and not as much on, you know, playing a melody the right way, and not the way it appears in a book. You know the way certain words take more time and so you borrow from something and rubato I guess, but even when you're playing in time, if you play literally what are in those books when you're playing standards, it would sound ridiculous. So

yeah, I look for that, somebody with a sound and a feel and a touch, who can really play a beautiful melody. And of course solo, but, you know.

MR: I remember you making a comment once about, I think it was Al Jarreau, and you were irked by — don't get up —

RM: Oh.

MR: That it was too affected. Everything had to have like something extra, or something like that. He couldn't just leave it alone.

RM: Yeah. I guess. I don't remember specifically saying it. I probably did. I probably said a lot of ridiculous things. But yeah, I think in general music today is so hyped up and, you know, everything has got to be bigger than life. People need something. It was funny my sister, my dearest sister, my older sister, the other day we were in a group of people and we were talking about music and somebody playing or somebody on TV and the way they expressed themselves, and she said "Rick, you used to move so much when you played, you really felt the music. And now you don't move at all." Uh yeah, thanks. You know, and I guess when I see some people film, I feel like I'm just planted there and it's all, I don't move. I move my fingers and I sit there.

RB: I've got a question.

RM: Yes, Romy.

RB: You've mentored so many people and you work so much, you know. And one time you told me, you said "I just want to play the piano." Like, you know, you have to go to the gig, you have to make the money, but has it lost its magic? Playing a gig? Or do you just want to go home and not have to play for the people?

RM: No not really. I mean honestly I would play anyway whether it was by myself or for people, it doesn't matter. I'm not hung up on, oh geez there's only a few people here, or the people aren't paying attention. If they want to pay attention that might be to their advantage but if not I'm still enjoying it. I love playing more than ever. I guess that's the thing. I get more out of music now than I ever have. So it's been like a constant climb up, in terms of what I'm extracting from the music.

MR: Nice.

RM: So I'm fortunate in that regard, and I do a lot of listening, just sitting and listening to music for long periods of time, and never tire of it.

MR: Wow. Did you meet Jill [his wife] in high school?

RM: I saw Jill when I was 15 years old. I was on a gig at Montgomery Wards in Rome, a live radio broadcast with Al Serway and Joe Abbis and Anthony Elliot, the great cellist, who was playing bass in those days, and Dave Derby was the announcer. How's that for remembering something.

MR: Where are you going this afternoon? Do you remember that?

RM: No I don't even know where I am right now. But yeah, so I saw Jill. She was with her then-boyfriend and I knew him. We were playing in this tent at Montgomery Wards in Rome in the parking lot at some kind of grand opening or something. And she came in with him and immediately it was like oh my Lord, you know, who is that? How can I get next to her? You know. And then I didn't see her for another three years. But I thought about her for three years. And then I started playing with a saxophone player by the name of Tony Madonia. I don't know if you remember him, Monk.

MR: Nope.

RM: You might have. He died very early, and he might have been around when you first came into Rome, right around that time maybe he passed away. But I started playing in his band and as it turned out Tony was married to Jill's sister and they lived in a duplex house and Jill lived on the other side. And when I was pulling into his house she came out on the porch and my world changed.

MR: I remember some anecdote about you jumping over the organ or something at Birdland to defend her honor or something like that.

RM: Yeah that actually did happen.

MR: Yeah? Well good for you.

RM: I'm not going to go into the details. I was a little tougher in those days and a little stupider. Stupider?

MR: A little more stupid.

RM: Thank you.

MR: Anyway, it's pretty cool how your son [Rick Montalbano Jr.] has found his way into music. And I bet he was a drummer from an early age.

RM: Yes, from — he was sitting at the drums from when he was an infant he would be on my lap or Jill's lap, and it was one of the ways — he was a very loud, hyper kid and one of the ways we would calm him down is to put on music and sit him on our lap and put the sticks in his hands and he would just start — and pretty soon it was obvious that he was actually playing the songs. He was playing the melody on the drums you know. So yeah, he showed signs of getting it from very early on. I could never quite get him to go to the piano the way he should have because he could have really been a good piano player. But a little bit of the father-son thing with the piano. But see I didn't play the drums that well. I only played the drums for amusement. So I think he figured out right away that he could beat me at that. Yeah I can remember Sal Nistico in our music room at home, staying at my house and we were in there playing and Ricky just snuck in and he was just a little, I don't know, three years old or four years old or something. He came in and we were working out some tunes and he sat down at the drums and started playing. And Sal just was playing like he didn't realize what was going on at first. Then he happened to look

over and he did a double take, like what the heck is that, you know, your kid's playing the drums and we're playing. We were playing. We weren't like playing to make him sound good, he was playing with us and it was working. And when he looked over at Ricky, Ricky stuck his tongue out at him. And for days afterwards he would just say "man, what's with your kid?"

MR: That's great. Do you remember the first time you took him out on a gig?

RM: He would sit in a lot. And one time when he was about seven I was playing at the time for Dominick Bruno. Do you remember the name Dominick Bruno? He owned a club in Syracuse called Three Rivers Inn for years and years. It was the big showroom of Central New York, all the acts of Sammy Davis Jr. and Bobby Darin and all those people. Everyone played there. That was the place. And he owned the place. The place burned down at one point. It was fortunate because he happened to get the piano and the organ out of there just the night before it burned down, amazingly.

MR: Wow.

RM: What kind of — so now he owned the Hotel Oneida and we were doing shows in the Hotel Oneida. Did you work any for me there?

MR: Yeah I think I did.

RM: Because I used to get all my friends on the gigs, you know J.R. [Monterose] played them and it was hilarious times. And Foster Brooks was the act. You remember Foster Brooks with his drunk act and all that. So it was on a Sunday and I went with Jill and Ricky. I took them along to the gig. And we were there a little early and the crowd was already there and Dominick decided let's go on now, but the band hadn't showed up yet. So I had to play Foster Brooks on. So I just said "Ricky, come up and play, we'll just play a blues, come up on the stage." He didn't think anything of it. He just went up to I think maybe Jimmy Johns' drums at the time, and just sat down behind the drums and we played a blues [scats] and he played and Foster Brooks came out and he starts doing his act and he turned back and again it was like one of those moments. He looked back and here's this little thing behind the drums. I mean nobody announced it or made a big deal in any way of it. Actually no one knew, we just went out and played him on. So he was quite taken with that. And the funniest part was Dominick Bruno, when he saw it, he just flipped and he decided we were going to put a group together with, do you remember the Harmonicats? With the little harmonica? What was the name Jerry? Anyway he was a friend of Dominick's. That was one of the groups that used to play at Three Rivers. So Dominick was going to put this band together with Ricky and me and this guy and a couple of other guys and we were going to go out on the road and he was just out of his mind over this idea of a little kid and a little guy playing together somehow. So yeah, so that's what would happen. He would come and he would sit in on gigs. And then when I

had a wedding band in the eighties I mean he could come up and play the whole gig with us and sometimes he would. And you would never notice, there was never — okay we're playing with a kid who doesn't know, we've got to make concessions. It was never that. He just played the gig. So he got a lot of experience early on.

MR: He also had the unfortunate honor of being on one of the two gigs that I've ever forgotten about, that you booked me for, to come to the Beeches and play for a bunch of women, and it was supposed to be him and myself. And something happened in my calendar.

RM: Right.

MR: And I didn't show up.

RM: Yes I remember that.

MR: And it was like oh my God. I said I don't know, Rick, a drum solo? Oh God I felt so bad.

RM: That was for Ava Dorfman, there was a senior center in Rome. Yeah she was quite upset.

MR: Yeah. I think I ended up going there and doing a make-up or something.

RM: You did. Yeah it was fortunate that didn't happen often did it?

MR: No.

RM: It did happen to me once or twice in my whole life and it was so bizarre, you just feel so —

MR: It's different when other people don't show up to work, well I didn't show up to work today, you know, someone else filled in for me on the cash register or something.

RM: I would say I got fogged in. Works for everything. "Why didn't you show?" "I got fogged in." "Well there was no fog." "Well there's lots of ways to get fogged in.

MR: Did you ever consider moving somewhere else, from Rome?

RM: Yeah I wanted to move to New York. And at the end of the Lou Rawls days I probably should have stayed out in Las Vegas or in LA, and I had a lot of opportunities to do things, but you know, I was married and then Jill got pregnant and I came home and made a go of it here.

MR: Yeah.

RM: It was a little frustrating at first, but there's great musicians here just like anywhere else. Maybe not as many, but I still had my sights on going to New York, but I never felt like I was quite up to it in those days. I didn't feel — I needed a little more work. I needed to get better before I go there. And then I got so entrenched here, I got so much work, I was fortunate I got so much work, why would I leave?

MR: I think people —

RM: My friend Jimmy Wormworth would say "you've got to come, you could work three to four nights a week here." I'm working six and seven nights here.

MR: You know how many times I'm working Saturday? Come on.

RM: Yeah I've got four gigs Saturday, and a Sunday brunch.

MR: Very interesting.

RM: That's one of the things probably about this area, you do get a chance to do a variety of things that maybe you wouldn't at a bigger — like a New York setting. You know, because right away you get kind of put into a niche and even if you're a jazz player, are you a straight ahead player, are you a modern guy, are you traditional? They have all these little sub-niches within the niche. And here you can play with the Syracuse Symphony one day, go play a show at the casino, go play a jazz gig, play a solo gig, you know a dance thing, whatever. So I think you get afforded sometimes, some opportunities that you'd be shut out of in a bigger, more competitive market.

MR: And also, did you ever go to your gig at the Savoy and say, "you know what, it just took me three minutes to get here and I don't have to unload and go park the car."

RM: Actually it's two minutes and 45 seconds from door to door. And if I can't park exactly in front of the place I'm bugged. If I have to park like 20 yards away, that's it, I'm bugged the whole night.

MR: Messed up your timing.

RM: It's not a bad place to be, really. It's not.

MR: No. It's not. I had someone say to me once "how can you do those piano gigs? Doesn't it bug you when people come up and ask for songs?" Well no man. It bugs me if I don't know them.

RM: Right.

MR: But, you know, I don't mind playing "My Way" you just play it good and then you feel okay about it.

RM: I'm the same way. If I don't know a tune I'm so bugged with myself.

MR: Well here's a hard one to sort of wrap up here. Do you remember, is there any gig or a series of gigs stand out as one of the most memorable or greatest things ever?

RM: Hmm. That's a tough question. I don't know, Monk. I don't think I could pick a particular gig. I could tell you some of the things I've really gotten a lot of enjoyment out of lately, when I get to the chance to play with my son and my daughter-in-law [Jane Monheit], in that setting, when their piano player — a couple of weeks ago he was in Spain I guess doing something and they had a gig in Massachusetts so I went in and filled in and it was just a ball to play in that setting with them, and to play with my son, and to play music like that, those great tunes and beautiful arrangements and a great piano, where people listen to you. You know so that's been a particular joy. The other one is my regular Wednesday night gig in Syracuse with Pastabilities, with John Rhode and Jimmy Johns. You know we've been there, I don't know, eight or nine years maybe, every Wednesday night in that setting, saxophone, vibes and piano, and when Ricky's in town he plays with us. That's been a particular joy lately. I don't know what I would do

without that gig. You know it's one of those opportunities to do original material and arrangements, organized. You know we've played together so long. And it's a little odd combination of things so the way we voice things and work out arrangements is a source of interest. J.R. Monterose used to say "you've got to stay interested." When he first started saying it — but the older I get I realize that's so true. That's so true. I look for things that interest me. Musical opportunities.

MR: Yeah. It's really nice to have a gig like that every week because during the week I'll bet you're thinking about, when you're driving, you say "well we could try this."

RM: All week long that's like the X in my week.

MR: Nice.

RM: Wednesday night, seven o'clock. And everything is kind of what are we going to do, this tune and then afterwards it's like I could have done this or that. So it's a source of great pleasure.

MR: What about your worst gig ever?

RM: Probably the worst gig in my recent history was a Christmas party that Tony Cee booked me for. It was a solo piano gig at the Radisson or at the Sheraton in Utica, an office Christmas party. And they had a piano, a little upright piano or something there. And I was very thorough when he was calling me for the gig, "are you sure they want just piano music? They're not looking for a band? They're not looking for a singer?" "No, no, no, they just want some Christmas tunes, nice background music, and that's it." "You're positive?" "Yes, of course." And I show up and of course they wanted Atlas Linen Company, you know, or one of those bands. And that was a difficult one. And I had one girl there who just harassed me all night. "You suck." And by the end of the night I was going "You suck." So yeah, that was a tough one. You're by yourself on a little piano and what am I going to do. "Play some Elvis!" "Elvis? Okay."

MR: "Blue Christmas." And you look at your watch and it's going backwards. This gig will never end.

RM: Yeah. It's in reverse. Exactly. So but generally, lately, you know these days the gigs are not that bad. But I find I play with less and less people — the people I actually play with. It's come down to like a little core. It used to be I had gigs with everyone, when I was young especially. You know, you play with everybody in the area. Now it's just not that many. Not that many people want to play with me probably.

MR: You played with Lionel Hampton, didn't you?

RM: Sure.

MR: Was that a road gig?

RM: That was a jazz festival down in the Poconos somewhere. Kenny Burrell, Lionel Hampton and there were a bunch of people. J.R. was on that. Yeah. I've been kind of fortunate in the people I've played with.

MR: I know you've mentioned one thing that I think you very much like is when a horn player or a singer has their own sense of time. You used to tell me to listen to Dolores [Mancuso] how she, and Sal Amico too.

RM: Right. Yes. Yeah. Those are people, you don't have to make the box for. They're in the box by themselves. We are all sharing the same concept. So you can do what you have to. You don't have to feel obligated to square everything off and set a foundation for them. So it makes it more interesting and more fun to play that way. You can stretch out behind them. Sal, once he started playing he didn't need anything.

MR: Once he started playing. I remember I used to watch him and he'd just be going [soft scatting], and then all of a sudden like, oh, when did the song start?

RM: Yeah. He was like cranking the engine, turning it, getting all the cylinders firing and then, once they started firing bango.

MR: That was great.

RM: Beautiful.

MR: Well anything you want to add to your conversation here today that I didn't —

RM: How about a word of advice to all young musicians going into the business?

MR: That's — thank you.

RM: And my only advice is don't ever leave your wallet in the dressing room when you go on stage. That's it. It's the only advice I can give.

MR: That's a good one. It came from experience huh?

RM: That's right.

MR: God forbid you lose your musician's union card too.

RM: Are you still in the union?

MR: Yes I am but, I don't know. They up and moved. Well thank you.

RM: Thank you, Monk and Romy.

MR: It's been a real pleasure.

RM: Thank you very much. I hope it was okay. I had a ball.

MR: It was great.

RM: Okay.

MR: Okay. Over and out.